

One message in. A tested service out.

A four-seat software factory in BAND Desktop built a wallet-and-payments service across **4 of 4 stages** from one dispatched task, with no human in the loop.

THE FACTORY

Four seats, four jobs, no overlap

Architect

Claude Code · opus-5-5

Reads the whole spec, writes invariants and an acceptance list, sends every handoff, reports once.

Implementer

Claude Code · opus-5-5

One scoped work item at a time. Own tests, own commit, own author line.

Reviewer

Claude Code · opus-5-5

Attacks the exact revision against every spec sentence. ACCEPT or REJECT with a reproduction.

Verifier

Claude Code · sonnet-5-5

No-cache build, offline 2 vCPU / 2 GiB container, earlier stages still green. RELEASE or REJECT.

Review asks *"does it meet the spec?"* Release asks *"does it survive a clean, capped, offline container?"* Different failures, so they are different seats.

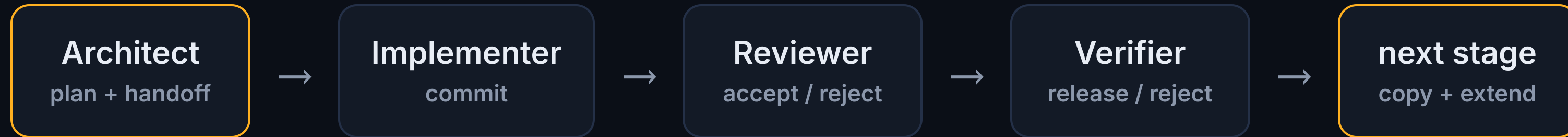
GENERIC MANDATES

Mandates say **how**, never **what**

- No endpoints, field names, error codes or domain words in any mandate. The product lives only in the task message.
- All four pass the organisers' vocabulary scan for **both** tracks (**harness check**).
- Test we used: could a team building something unrelated reuse these files unchanged?
- Rules learnt in rehearsal are generic too: per-seat git authors, foreground checks, direct-send handoffs.

LIFECYCLE

Every unit goes through the same loop



- Handoffs are self-contained: the full spec is pasted in, with the absolute repo path, work item and commands.
- A rejection loops back to the Implementer with the cited requirement, then through review again.
- Released stages are frozen; the next stage starts as a copy.

AUTONOMY

The only human input: one message

20:32:50 Human posts the task to @architect. This is the only human message.

20:37 Architect commits the stage-1 plan and hands W1 to the Implementer

21:13 Reviewer rejects W1 with 4 findings; fixed and accepted at 21:27

21:40 Stage 1 RELEASED by the Verifier (isolated, 147/147)

00:10 Stage 2 RELEASED: holds and captures API + browser UI

01:45 Stage 3 RELEASED: statements, as-of history, corrections

02:46 Stage 4 RELEASED: refunds and batch corrections

02:47 Architect posts the final report to the human (UTC, 4–5 Oct 2026)

SELF-CORRECTION

The band caught its own defects

3

reviewer / verifier rejections

28

seat commits, each under its own author

87

room messages between seats

- Stage 1: a malformed handle returned 422, not 404; resetting 1000 users took over 10 s; settlement errors came back out of order.
- Stage 2: an empty open hold could be captured as a 0-amount payment; an import could push available funds below zero.
- Stage 3: importing an expired-but-future hold pushed the server clock hours ahead, and resets did not undo it.

RESULT

Graded the way the organisers grade

STAGE	SHIPPED CHECKS (ISOLATED: OFFLINE, 2 VCPU, 2 GIB)	RELEASED
1 · payments, requests, splits, feed, settlements	147 / 147	21:40Z
2 · holds & captures + browser UI	147 + 35 / 35	00:10Z
3 · statements, as-of history, corrections	+ 6 / 6	01:45Z
4 · refunds, batch corrections	+ 5 / 5 · claimed stage 4	02:46Z

6 h 15 m

dispatch → final report

\$60.09

BAND estimate at list prices, 164 M tokens (not a bill)

What broke before it worked

RUN	FAILURE	GENERIC FIX
Attempt 1	A host MCP server shadowed BAND's own; the Implementer never started	Seats run with strict MCP config
Attempt 2	Implementer's reply-to-message report was dropped; the band stalled	All work messages use direct send, then confirm
Attempt 3	Submitted run: one dispatch, fresh room, empty repo	4 / 4 stages released

Abandoned runs are documented in FACTORY.md. Nothing from them was carried into the submitted repository.

REPRODUCE IT

Stand it up in about 30 minutes

- Install BAND Desktop and create four Claude Code seats.
- Load `mandates/*.md` as their standing instructions.
- Put them in one room and post one task to `@architect`.
- Grade with `python -m harness run --all --mode isolated`.

github.com/kmt9967/dark-factory-pocketful